

RESPONSE



Under-standing: The ‘sleeping beauty’ of educational metaphors

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Abstract

In this article, we argue that the term ‘understanding’ may be best understood as a ‘sleeping’ or ‘dormant’ metaphor, its metaphoricity ‘slumbering just below the surface’, waiting to be awakened. By engaging in a process of re-etymologisation, we re-establish the metaphorical character and potency of ‘understanding’ and explore some of the key implications for education. As a metaphor, the term ‘understanding’ highlights the relational and positional nature of what it might mean to understand and enables us to better describe the relationships between the subject and the object of understanding.

KEYWORDS

education, metaphor, understanding

INTRODUCTION

Despite its centrality to most, if not all educational endeavours, what is meant by understanding is not at all clear and is highly contested (Ross, 2018). In the words of Werner Mamacher, ‘understanding is in want of understanding’ (as cited in Sauter, 2017, p. 1032). Even a fairly recent resurgence in theorising about the nature of understanding in both philosophy (see e.g. Chart, 2000; Grimm et al., 2017; Janvid, 2014; Mason, 2003) and education (see e.g. Davson-Galle, 2004; Entwistle, 2009, 2018; Newton, 2012; Walshe, 2020) has not resulted in a consensus (Baumberger et al., 2017). Part of the difficulty lies in the fact that ‘understanding’ is used in a variety of different ways, including:

- The ability to comprehend, grasp or perceive an item of knowledge;
- Denote agreement, an arrangement or contract;
- Confirm awareness of something;

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Key insights

What is the main issue that the paper addresses?

This paper addresses the ambiguity surrounding the concept of 'understanding' in education. It argues for a reconceptualization that moves beyond dominant educational discourses and the primacy afforded to propositional understanding, and proposes an alternative view of understanding. Throughout this article, we adopt the convention in cognitive science literature of the use of small capitals (SMALL CAPITALS) to signify metaphors.

What are the main insights that the paper provides?

This paper contends that the term 'understanding' is fundamentally metaphorical and examines the conceptual metaphor UNDERSTANDING IS UNDER-STANDING. It argues that this metaphor reveals the inherently relational character of understanding, challenging reductive interpretations in educational discourse.

- Allude to a person's sympathetic and considerate nature;
- Express empathy and compassion; and
- Infer belief.

That we use this one word to refer to a variety of mental conditions that can mean different things in different contexts (Newton, 2012) and be applied to a range of targets (White & Gunstone, 1992), contributes to the difficulty in defining it.

Moreover, even when we appear to be talking about understanding in the same context (e.g. as an educational goal), it is not clear whether we are referring to 'objectual understanding', that is *understanding of* the subject matter; 'propositional understanding', *understanding that* something is the case; 'explanatory understanding', *understanding why* something is the case; or 'performative understanding', the *ability to act* as a consequence of understanding (Grimm et al., 2017; Walshe, 2020). Indeed, debates concerning the relationship between knowledge, understanding and belief represent one of the most prominent themes in the literature (Ross, 2018), and it is against this complex backdrop that we consider what might be meant by 'understanding' in the context of education.

Whilst it is beyond the scope of this article to examine in detail the associations and interrelations between the forms of understanding identified above, we suggest that the complexity surrounding what might be meant by 'understanding' is at least in part the result of the different relationships that exist between the subject and the object of understanding. Describing and explaining understanding is about describing and explaining these relationships (Baumberger et al., 2017; Smith & Walshe, 2025). Given the problematic nature of the endeavour, Mason (2003, p. 34) concludes that any attempt to provide a comprehensive account of what might be meant by understanding will not lead to a valuable theory, as 'there is a real philosophical puzzle about how what sort of account of understanding would satisfy'. Indeed, some have argued that previous attempts to provide coherent and comprehensive accounts of understanding are part of the problem. Rather than furthering our understanding, the definitions offered have contributed to the limited conceptualisation of understanding in teaching, learning and assessment (Baumberger et al., 2017; White & Gunstone, 1992).

The quest to understand 'understanding', or more particularly, the relationships between the subject and the object of understanding, is the motivating force behind this article, and arguably, should be of primary concern to all those involved in education (Wiggins & McTighe, 2005). After all, if we are going to put understanding 'up front and on the centre' of the educational stage, 'we had better know what we are aiming at' (Perkins, 1998, p. 39). In what follows, we explore what might be meant by 'understanding' (specifically, the verb 'to understand') through the lens of metaphor. Our intention is not to arrive at a conclusive definition but rather to enhance our understanding of what might be meant by 'understanding'. By awakening the metaphor embedded in the term through a process of re-etymologisation, we explore how conceiving of 'understanding' as 'under-standing' emphasises its relational nature (adopting a position in relation to the object of understanding) in contrast to the primacy given to propositional understanding in much of mainstream educational discourse (Hager, 2007; Lang, 2011). Our aim is not to suggest that propositional understanding has no place in education, but rather to 'trouble the taken-for-grantedness assumptions' about what might be meant by 'understanding', thus 'revealing an expanded landscape with significant implications for educators, students, and educational theorists' (Lang, 2011, p. 76; 75). As we will show, paying close attention to the metaphor 'UNDERSTANDING IS UNDER-STANDING' allows us to better describe the relationships between the subject and the object of understanding.

The pervasiveness of metaphors in our everyday life has long been established (Kövecses, 2020; Lakoff & Johnson, 2003). However, views on metaphor have shifted over the years (Cameron, 2003). At one end of the spectrum, metaphor has been regarded as merely ornamental, figurative, decorative and 'nice' (Badley & Van Brummelen, 2012, p. 5). According to this 'weak view' (Badley & Van Brummelen, 2012, p. 5), metaphor is a matter of poetic language and is purely cosmetic. At the other end of the spectrum, metaphor is perceived as 'necessary' (Badley & Van Brummelen, 2012, p. 5), and fundamental to our thinking and concept formation (Cameron, 2003). Proponents of this 'strong view' (Badley & Van Brummelen, 2012, p. 5), see metaphor as a matter of thought, not just of language, and maintain that our ordinary conceptual system is intrinsically metaphorical in nature—the way we think, our abstract concepts, what we experience, and what we do every day is largely, although not entirely, a matter of metaphor (Lakoff & Johnson, 2003). The logic of metaphor is the logic of our lives (Geary, 2011). Within this tradition, metaphor is central to the task of accounting for our perspectives on the world and how we make sense of reality, including how we generate and frame the problems we seek to solve (Schön, 1993). Metaphor theories sit at various points along this continuum, including those that occupy the middle ground, highlighting the interrelatedness of language and thought (Cameron, 2003) and arguing that whilst metaphors shape our practices, our practices also shape our metaphors (Badley & Van Brummelen, 2012).

As shall be evident from what follows, we concur with the key principles and assumptions of conceptual metaphor theories (CMTs), which contend that linguistic metaphors are not simply examples of figurative language but instantiations in language of conceptual metaphors (Cameron, 2010). In other words, the metaphors we use in our everyday conversations (such as 'LIFE IS A JOURNEY' and 'TIME IS MONEY') are conceptual tools, drawn from our experiences of participating in and engaging with the world around us that reflect how we structure, restructure and even create reality (Kövecses, 2017). Fundamentally, we think metaphorically. We instinctively resort to metaphor whenever we try to describe complex abstract ideas, concepts and feelings, etc. (Geary, 2011), and this is also true in education (Budaev et al., 2025; Craig, 2018).

Metaphors both reflect and shape how we think and talk about education and act as 'powerful cognitive models' (Botha, 2009, p. 432) through which educators and learners understand educational phenomena. Indeed, most of the theories basic to teaching, learning and education find their sources in metaphor (Botha, 2009). Here, we find ourselves 'in the

middle of a metaphorical blizzard' (Geary, 2011, p. 7) surrounded by metaphorical representations of education and its core activities and experiences such as:

- EDUCATION IS...TICKET TO PROSPERITY; JOURNEY; BRIDGE; FILLING AN EMPTY VESSEL; CATALYST.
- SCHOOL IS...FAMILY; MARKETPLACE; FACTORY.
- CURRICULUM IS...GARDEN; GREENHOUSE; PROCESS; MAP.
- EDUCATOR IS...GARDENER; MID-WIFE; POTTER; COACH; TOUR GUIDE; LION TAMER; SCULPTOR.
- LEARNER IS...TABULA RASA; BUCKET; SPONGE; CLAY; TRAVELLER; RHIZOME.
- TEACHING IS...TRANSMISSION; DELIVERY; PLANTING SEEDS.
- LEARNING IS...CLIMBING A LADDER; BUILDING A STRONG FOUNDATION.
- ASSESSMENT IS...MEASUREMENT.

We discuss the generative potential of educational metaphors in more detail in Section 5, for now it is sufficient to note that if it is indeed the case that we do not understand education until we understand its metaphors (Nelson, 2022), then arguably the same can be said of 'understanding'—we cannot understand 'understanding' without understanding its metaphors. We examine popular metaphors for understanding (such as UNDERSTANDING IS SEEING, UNDERSTANDING IS CONSTRUCTING, and UNDERSTANDING IS GRASPING) in a separate article (Walshe & Smith, 2025) and explore their entailments and contribution to our understanding of 'understanding' in the context of education. It was whilst completing this exercise that we became acutely aware of the metaphor embedded in the term 'understanding' itself, which is the primary concern of this article.

So, our purpose here is to draw attention to the metaphor inherent in the term 'understanding' (UNDERSTANDING IS UNDER-STANDING) and propose that this currently sleeping or dormant metaphor may be re-awakened by returning to its etymological roots. From there, we explore various ways in which the Old English term *understandan* was used. We suggest that for the most part, *understandan* referred to taking a stance, adopting a position in relation to the object of understanding, and consider some of the implications for education.

We deliberately refer to the 'sleeping beauty of metaphors' in the title of this article as it captures for us a sense of new beginnings, when something that has been slumbering for a long period of time is awakened from its repose. The story 'Sleeping Beauty' is one of the classic fairytales in Western Europe, although it is suggested that its origins lie further afield. The story revolves around a beautiful princess who, under a spell, sleeps for 100 years before being revived by a handsome prince. Whilst there are many adaptations of this story, in true fairytale style, the prince, the princess and their children 'live happily ever after' in popular versions. By referring to 'understanding' as 'the sleeping beauty of educational metaphors', we express something of our hope that by rousing this metaphor from its dormant state, we may 'unveil a world of new possibilities' (Guilherme & de Souza Freitas, 2018, p. 947).

THE METAPHOR OF 'UNDER-STANDING'

Whilst metaphors for understanding, such as 'UNDERSTANDING IS SEEING', are frequently employed in both educational and everyday discourse (see for example Walshe, 2020), the inherent metaphoricity of the term 'understanding' itself, hidden from plain sight and 'living a secret life all around us' (Geary, 2011, p. 5), has been overlooked. As we discuss below, in disregarding its metaphorical core and privileging other accounts, we run the risk of 'going off in dubious directions...making big mistakes' (Badley & Van Brummelen, 2012, p. 4) and missing what might be considered the most fundamental of answers to the question 'what does it mean to understand?'

Deeply embedded in everyday language we tend not to pay attention to its linguistic structure and consequently fail to notice its metaphorical character. It's easy to miss the fact that the word 'understanding' is comprised of two morphemes—the prefix 'under' and the verb 'standing'. This is perhaps not surprising as where two words fuse, 'the seamless grace of the resulting product or blend often deceives even the shrewdest observer who fails to notice the head of one animal joined to the tail of another' (Lieberman, 2005, p. 103). When viewed in this light, the metaphor implicit in 'under-standing' becomes clearer—'UNDERSTANDING IS UNDER-STANDING'. Understanding then, has something to do with 'standing under' that which is to be understood. To explore what exactly might be meant by this, necessarily involves delving into some quite complex discussion.

Our Modern English word 'understanding' is derived from the Old English term '*under-standan*' which, as we explore in more detail in Section 2.3 below, was used to signify, among others, 'to stand between, among, beneath or below'. Whilst its meaning is far from fixed, and it is by no means obvious how our contemporary sense of 'understand' developed from the formation of 'under' + 'standan' (Newman, 2001), there is a general consensus that 'understanding' appears to refer to the notion of taking a stance, adopting a position in relation to the object of understanding (see e.g. Jäkel, 1995; Lieberman, 2008; Newman, 2001).

In a conscious attempt to unveil, rather than continue to conceal its inherent metaphoricality, we shall employ the term 'under-standing' from this point onwards in this article, as we examine some of the key issues concerning our contention that 'UNDERSTANDING IS UNDER-STANDING' remains an important and vital metaphor in our conceptual system with significant implications for education.

Dead or alive?

According to Barfield (1973): 'every modern language ...is apparently nothing...but an unconscionable tissue of dead, or petrified metaphors'.

As with many other terms, 'understanding' has become conventionalised (Cameron, 2010), that is, it has become so much a part of our language code (Steen, 2007) that it has lost its metaphorical force and imaginative effectiveness (Nordquist, 2018) and has acquired a literal meaning only—'understand' now means 'understand' rather than 'under stand' or 'stand under'. This process of lexicalisation or entrenchment has led some (e.g. Jäkel, 1995) to conclude that 'understanding' is an example of a dead metaphor—no longer consciously perceived in its metaphorical terms and consequently, no longer 'vital'. However, this notion of dead metaphors is not only contested (see e.g. Alm-Arvius, 2006; Lakoff & Johnson, 2003; Reimer, 1996), but is one of the most, if not *the* most, controversial issues in debates about the nature of metaphor (Müller, 2008). Described by Lakoff as 'not workable' (1987, p. 143), by Lakoff and Turner as 'false' (1989, p. 130), and by Müller as 'untenable' (2008, p. 189), the dead metaphor theory divides opinion.

For some (e.g. linguistic metaphor theorists), metaphors that have become conventionalised and assimilated into our ordinary everyday language are 'dead' precisely because they have lost their vitality and original metaphorical force. Such metaphors recall only their literal meaning; that is, they call to mind the designated thing itself without reminding us of their original rich figurative language and associated imagery.

For others, (e.g. conceptual metaphor theorists), whilst conventionalisation or lexicalisation may lead to the entrenchment of previously novel metaphors in our language systems, it does not follow that those metaphors are 'dead' (see e.g. Allan, 2009; Alm-Arvius, 2006; Goldstein et al., 2012; Lakoff, 1987; Reimer, 1996). On the contrary, it is those metaphors that are most deeply entrenched in our ordinary everyday discourse, that are so automatic

and unconscious and effortless, that are the most alive (Lakoff & Turner, 1989), and active in the conceptual systems of language users (Müller, 2008); they govern our thoughts and are the metaphors we live by (Kövecses, 2010; Lakoff & Johnson, 2003). Thus, conventionalised metaphors retain their potential as metaphor as the essential metaphor-making comparisons are still vital and ongoing (Geary, 2011).

There are a few exceptions; however, where the original metaphorical sense is so historical as to render it no longer accessible. Such metaphors are well and truly 'dead and buried' (Goatly, 2011, p. 32). 'Pedigree' is often cited as an example of a dead and opaque metaphor, its transparency as a metaphor no longer evident to contemporary speakers/listeners and writers/readers. The original 'pedigree' metaphor (coming from the Old French '*pied de grue*' meaning 'foot of a crane') was based on an image metaphor that mapped the shape of a crane's foot onto the diagram of a family tree. As a metaphor, it is no longer vital as it has died both at the linguistic level (we do not use the term 'pedigree' to refer to a crane's foot) and at the conceptual level (we no longer look at the structure of a family tree and see its comparison to a crane's foot). 'Pedigree' is thus "a truly dead metaphor" (Lakoff & Turner, 1989, p. 129) with no hope of revival. Where a metaphor (such as 'pedigree') is 'dead' at both the linguistic and conceptual levels, it is best left to rest in peace. But where a metaphor may be 'dead' at just one level (e.g. the linguistic level) and alive at the other (e.g. the conceptual level), it may rise again like a phoenix from its ashes. Determining whether a given metaphor is truly dead or just unconsciously conventional, however, 'is not an easy matter' (Lakoff & Turner, 1989, p. 130).

Sleeping or Waking?

In refuting the dichotomous view of metaphors as either dead or alive, Müller (2008) argues that metaphors may be both dead *and* alive (our italics) and suggests that seemingly dead metaphors may simply be sleeping, their 'figurative nature slumbering unseen, just below the surface' (Geary, 2011, 25). Similar states such as 'dying', 'moribund' or 'faded' (Alm-Arvius, 2006, p.7); 'dormant'—like a volcano (Geary, 2011, p.25); 'inactive'—incorporating both 'sleeping' and 'merely tired' (Goatly, 2011, p.38); and 'frozen' (Kyratzis, 2003 as cited in Müller, 2008, p.189) have been used to classify conventionalised and 'so-called 'dead' metaphors' (Reimer, 1996, p. 13). Implicit in all is a sense that these are transitory points along a continuum of conventionality (Alm-Arvius, 2006; Goatly, 2011; Müller, 2008) and that such metaphors can be activated, revived, regenerated, awakened and roused from their current slumber, given the right circumstances (Goldstein et al., 2012) and contexts (Allan, 2009); the metaphorical connections are in place and just need to be 'switched on' (Goatly, 2011, p. 34). Their metaphoricity, or lack of it, is not fixed, but provisional, flexible, dynamic, scalable and gradable (Müller, 2008). The same expression may be more metaphorically active in certain contexts and less so in others. Given certain conditions, conventionalised metaphors can reclaim their lost meaning and 'be treated as unfamiliar expressions anew' (Goldstein et al., 2012, p. 137).

For Müller (2008), activation of the inherent metaphoricity in a sleeping metaphor is dependent on a mediator, that is, on the language use of the speaker/writer and the extent to which the listener/reader understands one thing (e.g. UNDERSTANDING) in terms of another (e.g. UNDERSTANDING): 'Without such a mediating force ... there is no establishment of metaphoricity' (Müller, 2008, p. 26). Consciousness of a metaphor as a metaphor at the individual level appears to be a principal criterion for some (see e.g. Goatly, 2011; Müller, 2008) for establishing the degree to which a metaphor may be considered alive/waking/sleeping/dead, or at least that its metaphoricity becomes more obvious on closer scrutiny (Alm-Arvius, 2006) and its 'cognitive content' (Reimer, 1996) intended by the speaker/writer is grasped by the listener/reader.

Whilst the *degree* of metaphoricity may not be a fixed property of a specific metaphoric expression (Müller, 2008, *our italics*), its metaphoric potential and potency are, regardless of whether the conceptual relationships between the source (e.g. JOURNEY) and target domains (e.g. LIFE) of the metaphor are obvious to contemporary speakers (Cameron, 2010; Geary, 2011; Lakoff, 1987). The metaphor 'under-standing' is a case in point. Whilst 'under-standing' has clearly become conventionalised and is part of our everyday language, it is our contention that its underlying metaphoricity is very much alive and kicking, exerting a powerful influence on the way we think; we just neglect to see it as such.

Etymological roots

According to Cameron and Maslen (2010), one way of determining a term's metaphoricity is to return to its etymological roots, as 'the etymologies of words for abstract concepts reflect their early conceptualisation' Kövecses (2020, p. 7). It is important to state at the outset that our intention is not to suggest that by returning to its etymological roots, we will somehow uncover the 'essential' or 'true' meaning of 'understanding', as the root of a word is not the key to its current meaning (Durkin, 2009; Liberman, 2005; Nelson, 2022). But rather that by engaging in a process of re-etymologisation (Trim, 2007, as cited in Allan, 2009, p. 296), we can explore the history of the concept 'understanding' through the history of language (Nelson, 2022), re-establishing transparency (Müller, 2008) and unveiling its metaphoric backdrop (Nelson, 2022). Etymology thus provides a sidelight with which to illuminate the past (Liberman, 2005). After all, 'a word is not explained until we find out the original of its meaning' (Wood, 1899, p. 130). Our intention here is to provide an overview of the various ways in which the Old English (OE) word '*understandan*' (from which the modern English term 'understanding' emerged) was used and to explore how its early usage might provide us with a possibly new and fruitful way of thinking about understanding, one that might offer a critical lens through which to review the primacy given to propositional understanding in much of mainstream educational discourse (Hager, 2007; Lang, 2011).

Bosworth Toller's Anglo Saxon online dictionary (Bosworth, 2014) identifies the following meanings associated with '*understandan*':

- To understand, have insight into
- To understand, perceive, know, certainly,
- To understand in such and such a sense, to conceive of, consider
- To accept as correct
- To observe, notice, consider

Returning to its etymological roots reveals that the term '*understandan*' (which appears in the early and late West Saxon periods) probably arose as a blend of the West Germanic verbs '*forstandan*' and '*undergietan*' (Liberman, 2008). Each of these carries a slightly different meaning: *forstandan* has a sense of 'to stand before/ in front of' or 'to snatch away' or 'to defend, obstruct, stop' whilst *undergietan* is taken to mean 'to get apart, to take to oneself' (Liberman, 2008). There appears to be a general consensus that *understandan* was the starting point for the development of a more abstract sense of the processes involved in coming to an understanding such as perception and observation (Liberman, 2008; Newman, 2001), whilst *undergietan* referred to the outcome (Ogura, 1993 as cited in Liberman, 2008, p. 212).

According to Liberman (2008), the inner structure of *understandan* (under+standan) has not changed since the time it was first recorded in 888. Its semantic meaning, however, has been the subject of much debate among etymologists, who have explored, among others, the following key questions:

Is understandan a separable or inseparable verb?

The extent to which *understandan* should be treated as a separable verb (*under*+*standan*) or an inseparable verb (*understandan*) is a matter of debate (see e.g. Ogura, 1995; Ono, 1989; Yookang, 2015) with some suggesting (see e.g. Hough, 2004; Yookang, 2015) that the compound word (*understandan*) is not necessarily equal in meaning to the sum of its parts (*under*+*standan*).

Both options can lead to different conclusions regarding the meaning of the term. Where it is considered separable, its meaning is established by determining what might be meant by both 'under' (e.g. 'below') and 'standan' (e.g. 'stand') and combining them (e.g. *under*+*standan* = 'to stand below'). However, there is some disagreement as to where the semantic weight lies—in the prefix or the verb stem (see e.g. Hough, 2004). Where it is treated as an inseparable verb, various meanings have been proposed including: 'to stand under', 'to withstand', 'to perceive', 'to have insight into', 'to observe', 'to notice', 'to conceive of', 'to consider', 'to take for granted' and 'to know for certain' (Newman, 2001).

What is meant by the prefix under?

What might be meant by the OE prefix/ adverb 'under' is not clear and remains poorly understood (Nagucka, 2008). It is suggested (e.g. Wood, 1999) that its meaning is best explained by its relation to the Old High German (OHG) word '*untar*' and the Latin (L) term '*inter*' meaning 'middle, between, separate'. This sense of 'separation' may then be understood in various ways: (a) to separate, distinguish, divide, stand between, keep apart, discern; (b) to separate, take away, take in, take to oneself, seize, attain; and (c) stand among, be physically close to (Newman, 2001). In this way, the OE word *understandan* could be said to have originally meant to 'stand among', 'stand between' and so 'to keep apart' and 'separate' (Hemphill, 1899). However, Liberman (2008, p. 215) introduces a note of caution with the reminder that 'the extent to which the idea of separation was prominent in the minds of those who first endowed verbal units like "stand beneath, among," "stand in front," "stand against" with the meaning "perceive, get to know, comprehend" is beyond reconstruction. Nor can we establish whether those words go back to popular usage or to the language of scholars (poets, priests)'. It is also suggested that 'under' in *understandan* may come from *ndher* (OGH) signifying 'under, beneath', below (see Liberman, 2008; Nagucka, 2008). Newman (2001) notes for instance, that not all etymological dictionaries accept the meaning 'between, among' for the prefix 'under' and instead cite the original meaning of *understandan* as 'stand under', which, as noted by Nagucka (2008) is consistent with that found in Shakespeare's *Two Gentlemen of Verona*: 'Why, stand under and understand is all one' (II, V:31).

Liberman (2008) concludes that neither 'stand between/among' or 'stand under' lead unambiguously to the meaning of the Modern English term 'understand'. Similarly, Newman (2001) notes how the semantics of the OE 'under' are considerably more complex than just a matter of a meaning of either 'under' or 'between among'. The line demarcating them is one of our own making (Liberman, 2008, p. 215). So, rather than either/or, the meaning of the prefix *under* in *understandan* may be both 'between/among' and 'beneath/below': "one 'stands under' and gets to the bottom of things, and whilst standing between or among things, one acquires the power of discrimination" (Liberman, 2008, p. 210). Indeed, according to Liberman (2008), this sense of 'under' in 'understand' as 'under, beneath' and 'between, among' is an old one, dating back to the eighteenth century. Further justification may be found in how *under* was used as a prefix in other words such as *undergietan* (OHG) where it meant both 'beneath' and 'among', hence 'between' (Liberman, 2008, p. 210). This is particularly apposite if, as noted above, *understandan*

emerged as a blend of the earlier the West Germanic verbs *forstandan* and *undergi-etan*. Regardless, it seems justifiable to conclude that the prefix *under* was used as a preposition or adverb in Old English primarily to signify spatial meaning, albeit vaguely (Lieberman, 2008). As a bearer of spatial relations, it indicated location or motional direction (Nagucka, 2008), and this prototypical function has been preserved up to now (Nagucka, 2008). For Newman (2001) however, the picture is more complex. His review of the semantics of ‘*under*’ verbs in Old English reveals that the prefix denoted more than just ‘under’ or ‘between, among’, and can be found, for instance, in verbs where ‘*under*’ denotes an element of secrecy or treachery.

What is meant by the verb stem ‘standan’?

Again, we find a lack of consensus, perhaps because, as suggested by Newman (2001), there is no ‘*standan*’ meaning documented for its place within *understandan*, and ‘the more meanings that are constructed, the more speculative the account becomes’ (Newman, 2001, p. 189). Bosworth Toller’s Anglo–Saxon Dictionary (Bosworth, 2014) (online) defines the OE verb ‘standan’ as:

To stand:	Of attitude
	Of situation or position
	Of condition
	Of constitution
	Of occupation or action
	To be fixed as a law or regulation
	To remain undisturbed
	To stand still, cease to move, remain without motion, stop
	To reside, abide
	To continue, remain
	To stand, not to fall, to be upheld
	Of direction

Although this does not provide us with any definitive sense of how *standan* was used in *understandan*, it does at least provide us with a starting point as most of the above include the notion of ‘taking a position’. Gibbs (1994) explores the idea of ‘standing upright’ whilst Newman (2001) shows that *understandan* may relate ‘to taking a stance’, in relation to both one’s emotional and intellectual attitude or position. A very different view is presented by Hough (2004) who argues that a hitherto overlooked Old English and now obsolete meaning of *standan* as ‘shine’ suggests that *understandan* may best be understood in terms of the metaphor UNDERSTANDING IS LIGHT, a proposal that Lieberman, for several reasons, finds ‘unpromising’ (2008, p. 214).

Conclusion

Whilst its exact meaning may not be fixed, and various alternatives have been offered as introduced above, most scholars conclude (see e.g. Jäkel, 1995; Lieberman, 2008; Newman, 2001) that the overall picture presented suggests that the Old English term

understandan may be said to have referred to taking a stance, adopting a position in relation to the object of understanding (Jäkel, 1995). Regardless of whether it meant to stand between, among, beneath or below, *understandan* appears to have acted as a metaphor of establishing physical closeness (Jäkel, 1995) to that which is being understood to get to know its characteristics and attributes (Lieberman, 2008). Thus, the relationship between the subject and the object of understanding is positional. As this represents the most commonly adopted view, it is the one that we will use to explore the metaphor UNDERSTANDING IS UNDER-STANDING, its entailments and implications for education.

UNDERSTANDING IS UNDER-STANDING

Having established its metaphoricity, we can now ask what kind of metaphor 'under-standing' is. Moreover, examining its entailments and structures allows us to explore its relationship to frequently used metaphors for understanding such as UNDERSTANDING IS SEEING, UNDERSTANDING IS CONSTRUCTING and UNDERSTANDING IS GRASPING.

Under-standing as a structural, ontological and orientational metaphor

According to Lakoff and Johnson (2003, p. 264), 'all metaphors are structural (in that they map structures to structures); all are ontological (in that they create target domain entities); and many are orientational (in that they map orientational image schemas)'. As illustrated above, the metaphor 'UNDERSTANDING IS UNDER-STANDING' may be classified as structural, ontological and orientational. It is structural in that it allows us to map characteristics associated with the concrete experience of 'STANDING UNDER' onto the abstract concept 'UNDERSTANDING', thus enhancing our understanding of what might be meant by 'understanding'. Indeed, Lieberman (2005) notes how words designating concepts such as love, hatred and fear (and to this list, we might add 'understanding'), usually referred in the beginning to concrete sensations; 'the starting point being the sensation one experiences' (p. 193). It is ontological in that it creates the target domain 'UNDERSTANDING', thereby conceptualising 'understanding' as an entity that can be referred to, described and quantified. Finally, it is orientational in that it utilises rich spatial orientation image schemas inherent in 'understanding' (such as standing between, among, beneath or below) to enrich our appreciation of what might be meant by 'understanding'.

Entailment relationships

According to conceptual metaphor theories, metaphors operate as a link or bridge between two conceptual domains: the source domain and the target domain (Lakoff & Johnson, 2003). This metaphorical transfer is unidirectional (Jäkel, 2002), from the source domain (which is usually physical, tangible, and rooted in our experience of the world) to the target domain, which tends to be more abstract. A metaphorical entailment (Lakoff & Johnson, 2003) or inference (Kövecses, 2010) or correspondence (Kövecses, 2020) is the imparting of a characteristic of the source domain (e.g. MONEY) to the target domain (e.g. TIME) by logical means, thus expressing something of our understanding of the target domain.

Drawing on the clues provided by returning to the etymological roots of the old English term *understandan* (Section 2.3), we outline below some of the key entailment relationships involved in the UNDERSTANDING (target domain) IS UNDER-STANDING (source domain) metaphor. To conceive of 'understanding' as 'under-standing' entails the following:

Encounter

To understand means to 'stand between/among/beneath/below', implying physical closeness to the object of understanding (Section 2.4). For Liberman (2008) this proximity allows for familiarity in that from this position, the subject can get to know the characteristics and attributes of the object of understanding. In this sense, the conceptual metaphors 'UNDERSTANDING IS SEEING' and 'UNDERSTANDING IS HEARING' are implied, as in that encounter, one must perceive, notice, observe, attend to, and consider in order to know the object of understanding.

Engagement

To understand means to 'stand between/among' the object of understanding, inferring that understanding may involve a process of separating out, distinguishing and dividing (see Section 2.3.2). This aspect of understanding is also reflected in the conceptual metaphor 'UNDERSTANDING IS CONSTRUCTING' where to understand is to examine the object of understanding, discern and study its constituent parts, see connections between them, and perceive how they fit together to form the whole. Such an approach prioritises a coherence, rather than a knowledge orientation towards understanding, where the emphasis is on the 'why' rather than just the 'what and how' (Burns et al., 1991) and reflects a constructivist or social constructivist view of understanding which holds that learning is a dynamic process in which the learner (individually or with others) actively constructs their own meaning (Walshe, 2020), gaining insight into that which is being understood. There is sense in which the subject gains control (Jäkel, 1995) in the process of imposing order (Lynch & Fisher-Ari, 2017); deciding which aspects to 'seize, attain, take in, and take to oneself' and which aspects to discard. In this way, understanding may involve mental manipulation as captured by the conceptual metaphor 'UNDERSTANDING IS GRASPING'.

Evaluation

To understand means to 'stand between/among/beneath/below'; infers that, having examined the object of understanding, there are decisions to be made about where I, as the subject, choose to stand in relation to it (Section 2.3.3). Each of the above (e.g. between, below) may be said to indicate something of the nature of the stance taken, for example:

- a. To 'stand between' may indicate indecision, for instance, between two or more perspectives. Moreover, to 'stand between' may involve standing in front of or before one interpretation/viewpoint/opinion and turning one's back on the other. Alternatively, it may suggest a compromise between them; an adopting of the middle ground; or a position of neutrality. To stand between could also imply a position of defence and protection, or obstruction, for example, as in withstanding or resisting or a change in thinking or behaviour.
- b. To 'stand among' may infer a particularly close relationship—one of support and close alignment with that which is being understood. In this way, 'to stand among' may be akin 'to stand by' and may point towards a 'taking for granted' and a sense of 'certain knowledge'. Moreover, to 'stand among' is reminiscent of Gibbs et al's (1994) CENTRE-PERIPHERY image schema where 'to stand' can be associated with being in the centre of things as if 'to get the heart of the matter'.
- c. To 'stand beneath/below' may infer a lower position in relation to the object of understanding—a distancing from it, or alternatively, a position of support, 'holding up' and reinforcing.

Whilst the above cannot be said to be a comprehensive analysis due to the constraints of this article, these entailments do provide useful insights into what might be meant by 'understanding' as they highlight the relational nature of understanding (Sauter, 2017), beginning with a deliberate encounter and engagement with the object of understanding (shaped by the subject's prior personal understandings), and resulting in the adoption of a stance (mental position) in relation to that which is being understood.

What is not clear is whether the spatial meanings associated with *understandan* (such as to stand beneath/below and to stand among/between) represented a fixed position and thus denoted the outcome (where I choose to stand in relation to the object of study) or whether they also referenced (albeit implicitly) the journey (how I came to arrive at that position). For instance, 'to stand below' may refer to the outcome, the position taken (Jäkel, 1995), but it may also imply a process in terms of the movement needed to get into that position (e.g. Liberman, 2008). For Liberman (2008), *understandan* was one of many verbs for understanding in the Indo-European languages, all of which developed from spatial metaphors whose idea it was that standing in a certain position allows the observer to get to know the properties of the object. That *understandan* has been used to signify proximity to, familiarity with, and taking a position (judgement) in relation to the object of study further adds to its complexity. Arguably, this tension is also present in the corresponding metaphor UNDERSTANDING IS UNDER-STANDING, containing within it, as within other popular metaphors for understanding, the potential to reference both product and process (Smith, 2018).

TOWARDS A NEW (OR RENEWED) CONCEPTION OF 'UNDERSTANDING'

As we have noted above, paying close attention to its etymological roots yields interesting insights into the various ways in which '*understandan*' was used in Old English (from which the Modern English term 'understanding' emerged). However, it is important to remember that 'we do not resort to etymology in order to discover an essential meaning in a word with the implication that we should return to it or rediscover its merits and revive them' (Nelson, 2022, p. 215) as words adapt, and through a process of semasiological development, their meanings change over time. Rather, recognising a metaphor as a metaphor allows us to explore the history of the ideas (Nelson, 2022) contained within. After all, 'the metaphors entombed in even the simplest words are not mere etymological curiosities. These fossils still breathe, exerting a potent but largely unnoticed influence on us' (Geary, 2011, p. 28).

Switching on (Goatly, 2011) the metaphor of 'understanding' to revive its metaphoricity that we may see its unfamiliarity anew (Goldstein et al., 2012) allows us to utilise its descriptive power to better describe the relationships between the subject and the object of understanding. By tracing the etymological roots of '*understandan*', we make the unconscious conscious (Nelson, 2022). What emerges is a historical landscape where 'understanding' was seen at least in part, if not principally, as having something to do with knowing from the perspective of a particular placement, standing between, among, beneath or below a thing, and getting to know its properties (Liberman, 2008, p. 210) and consequently, arriving at a judgement or standpoint. Whilst it does not follow accordingly that this is how we should understand 'understanding' today, reawakening the metaphor provides us with a compelling kaleidoscopic lens through which to review contemporary conceptions of 'understanding' and to consider how far from its linguistic and conceptual roots the Modern English term 'understanding' may have travelled.

Waking the sleeping metaphor 'under-standing' 'shakes things up' (Geary, 2011, p. 16), resulting in a new, or rather renewed, conception of 'understanding' with significant implications for educational knowledge, policy, and practice (Section 5). 'A good metaphor, like

a bolt of lightning, provides a sudden flash of insight, a glimpse of illuminated ground on which experiments can be made. Things look strange when lit by lightning, but it is that very strangeness that enables us to see them differently' (Geary, 2011, p. 207). Against an educational backdrop where 'the primacy of knowledge has so deeply affected the ways in which learning is understood' (Martin & Martínez de Pisón, Martin & de Pisón, 2005, p. 158), the metaphor UNDERSTANDING IS UNDER-STANDING unveils a 'diversity of novel perspectives and a world of new possibilities' (Guilherme & de Souza Freitas, 2018, p. 947) and allows us to see 'understanding' differently from the way it appears in dominant educational discourses as primarily concerned with the acquisition, retention and recall of propositional knowledge. Such a view of 'understanding' prioritises the MIND IS A CONTAINER metaphor, which, whilst handy for talking about the acquisition of knowledge, is not helpful when talking about what the knowledge is good for once it is in the container (Bereiter, 2002). Described by Bereiter (2002) as a "ghost in [Bloom's] taxonomy" (p. 94), understanding is often reduced in education to a set of skills and competencies (Hager, 2004) rather than having something to do with how a person relates to and deals with the world around them (Davis, 2018). For Bereiter (2002), educators should be less occupied with what is *in* students' minds [our italics] and more concerned with what kinds of relationships are developing between the students and those conceptual artefacts that find their way into the curriculum.

Furthermore, the notion that all metaphors are ultimately derived from our direct experience of the world (Geary, 2011) reflects the view that all thinking and knowing is embodied; that we experience the world in the way that we do because of the nature of our physical selves and our interaction with our environment (Deignan, 2010; Johnson, 2018). The embodied nature of knowledge is an established concept across a range of disciplines, including education (Craig, 2018). Drawing on the work of philosopher Merleau-Ponty, Stolz maintains that 'we do not think about the world from some position beyond the body or outside it, ... our being is necessarily present in it and involved with it.' (Stolz, 2015, 480). As a metaphor, UNDERSTANDING IS UNDER-STANDING captures the very essence of embodied learning or situated knowledge (Lang, 2011). We engage in a process of meaning-making from our own perspectives (informed by our prior personal understandings) and by means of orientating ourselves in relation to the object of understanding, hence the iterative process suggested above.

To conceive of 'understanding' as a process of orientating or positioning ourselves in relation to the object of understanding is not a new idea; however, it is one that is sidelined in much educational discourse, which tends to prioritise propositional understanding (see e.g. Entwistle & Entwistle, 1991; Gardner & Box-Mansilla, 2006; Maclellan, 2005). Furthermore, according to Harrison (2017), it is a conception associated with Eastern rather than Western philosophy, where the activities of knowing and understanding are more frequently mapped onto the domain of sight (and indeed, of physically grasping and manipulating an object). As Lakoff and Johnson explain (1999), the metaphors KNOWING IS SEEING and UNDERSTANDING IS SEEING are so central to our conception of knowledge that we are seldom aware of how they structure our sense of what it is to know or understand something. For Harrison (2017), these metaphors are directly related to a western emphasis on empirically observable and verifiable evidence. She argues that within traditional Chinese thought KNOWING/UNDERSTANDING IS SEEING plays a secondary role to another primary metaphor, that of locomotion or movement: "within traditional Chinese thought, the sense of knowing is primarily brought to conceptualisation by mapping it one to the more fundamental sense of moving one's body" (Harrison, 2017, p. 47). As we have outlined above, this sense of movement is present in the metaphor UNDERSTANDING IS UNDER-STANDING where 'understanding' is conceptualised as TAKING A POSITION.

HOW WE THINK METAPHORICALLY MATTERS

How we think metaphorically matters as metaphors are not simply examples of figurative language. They are conceptual tools, drawn from our experiences of participating in and engaging with the world around us that reflect how we structure, restructure and even create reality. Metaphors are thus an integral part of the meaning-making process itself and a fundamental schema by which people conceptualise the world (Kövecses, 2017; Lakoff & Johnson, 2003).

Metaphors as powerful heuristics

How we think metaphorically in education matters as the 'unavoidable, influential and enriching' metaphors (Badley & Van Brummelen, 2012, p. 3) used by educators to reflect on and communicate their experiences act as powerful heuristics (Craig et al., 2017) with the potential to yield fresh insights into their beliefs, attitudes and practices (McGrath, 2006). Recent decades have witnessed a keen interest in research in pedagogical metaphorology, led in particular by researchers from North America and Europe (Budaev et al., 2025). This prolific research has resulted in the emergence of new and imaginative educational metaphors such as those selected below relating to teacher identity:

- TEACHER IS A COAT HANGER (Thomas & Beauchamp, 2011)
- TEACHER IS A GERBIL ON AN EXERCISE WHEEL (Thomas & Beauchamp, 2011)
- TEACHER IS A LIGHT BREEZE (Efron & Bolotin, 2000)
- TEACHER IS A SPUMONI ICE CREAM (Patchen & Crawford, 2011)
- TEACHER IS A PETRI DISH (Gillis & Johnson, 2002)
- TEACHER IS QUEEN OF ENGLAND (Erickson & Pinnegar, 2017)

As 'archetypes' and 'blueprints' of professional knowledge and thinking, these educational metaphors both express and shape educators' understanding of the nature and purpose of education and its various activities such as teaching and learning (Martinez et al., 2001, p. 966). Their generative power (Schön, 1993) lies in their ability to provide 'new vantage points' (Martinez et al., 2001, 973) from which a teacher can look at his/her own and to act as springboards for change (Gillis & Johnson, 2002; Serefoglu et al., 2009).

Metaphors as carriers of epistemic and ideological freight

How we think metaphorically matters as metaphors matter carry 'epistemic and ideological freight' (Botha, 2009). To conceive of education as a JOURNEY, for instance, reveals significantly different beliefs, values and assumptions to those inherent in metaphors such as 'TICKET TO PROSPERITY' or 'ANTIDOTE TO IGNORANCE'. Were we to unpack these three metaphors in detail, we would find that each would engender quite distinctive approaches to teaching, learning and assessment. For example, conceiving of education as an ANTIDOTE TO IGNORANCE implies that learning is concerned with the acquisition of information with which to slay the demons Ignorance and Misinformation. Consequently, the role of the educator is primarily to assess misconceptions and transmit knowledge into the minds of their students. Arguably, the metaphors of TRANSMISSION and ACQUISITION have hitherto dominated much educational policy and practice (Budaev et al., 2025; Badley & Hollabaugh, 2012; Sfard, 1998).

As Nelson (2022, p. 218) notes, not all our educational metaphors are 'totally good', indeed, some may be considered 'mildly odious'. We might add the currently endemic metaphors of MARKET and BUSINESS (Budaev et al., 2025) to this list of mildly odious

educational metaphors, as the marketisation of education has been shown to lead to inequalities in society (Guilherme & de Souza Freitas, 2018), individualisation and learnification (Säfström & Månsson, 2022), and has resulted, particularly in England, in 'heightened levels of centralised regulation' and 'the codification, economisation and instrumentalisation of educational processes and outcomes linked to a data rich performance management system based upon high stakes standardised testing and high stakes inspections that provide information to educational consumers in competitive markets' (Hall, 2023, p. 63). Similarly, Cook-Sather (2003) critiques two educational metaphors which, she argues, have dominated notions and practices of formal schooling in the United States and which she would undoubtedly wish to add to the above list, namely EDUCATION IS PRODUCTION and EDUCATION IS CURE. Both, she suggests, 'keep students passive, as products or patients, confined within institutions that contain and control, like factories and hospitals, and managed by teachers who are technicians or managers on the one hand or diagnosticians and therapists on the other' (Cook-Sather, 2003, p. 959). These metaphors matter, as carried to their extreme, they may 'sacrifice the human spirit and soul for the efficiency of scientific management and mass production' (Cook-Sather, 2003, p. 956).

Metaphors as gatekeepers

Moreover, metaphors matter as not only do our educational metaphors disclose deeply held beliefs about the nature and purpose of education, but they also act as gatekeepers (Cameron, 2003) and provide access to disciplinary premises regarding the way the world works, what can be known, and how. As such, Botha (2009, p. 433) argues that educational metaphors should be included as part of the taught content so that students, as well as educators, may 'discern the underlying assumptions at work in a particular discipline' as a student cannot understand a subject without paying some attention to its metaphors. After all, 'if students are to become mature members of discipline areas, they will need to meet, understand and acquire the technical metaphors of the field' (Cameron, 2003, p. 269). Indeed, deliberate and purposeful use of metaphors as a pedagogical tool in the classroom (Lynch & Fisher-Ari, 2017) has been found to yield positive results. Students taught through metaphor have been found to perform better than other students in terms of the acquisition and retention of new knowledge, conceptual recall, problem solving (Mayer, 1993), and critical thinking skills (Littlemore, 2016) and make fewer conceptual errors (Cameron, 2003). According to Stitch (1993), the key to success lies in the explicit use of metaphor as a metacognitive tool in the classroom, to stimulate knowledge invention, rather than simply knowledge retention. So, the metaphor of understanding as under-standing, if communicated to students as taking a position, can be used to enable them to open the gate to being aware of what can be known and how—to understand in a way that is shared with those in the discipline being taught.

Metaphors as springboards for change

According to Gillis and Johnson (2002), the possibility of change is implicit in the metaphors we create as evidenced by Craig et al. (2017) who note how their research into school reform in the United States led one participating teacher to conceive of her own practice as A STRAND OF PEARLS. This novel emergent metaphor allowed her to distinguish between aspects of her practice that qualified as 'pearls' (requiring continuous polishing and refinement) and those that did not (where teaching and learning had not fused as anticipated). Moreover, when one of her colleagues (a substitute teacher) considered her own practice in the light of this metaphor, she described it (in contrast) as a collection of unwieldy glass beads made

of different shapes and colours with nothing tying them together. Having realised why her pedagogic practice (beads) felt cumbersome, she embarked on a search for a meaningful medium to string her beads together.

These and other similar creative metaphors elicited by researchers in the field provide useful windows into teachers' professional thinking and practice (Saban, 2006; Serefoglu et al., 2009). Moreover, not only do such metaphors represent the values and professional position of the educator, they can also reflect the prevailing ideology and changing educational paradigm at a given point (Budaev et al., 2025). If that is the case, and if Davis (2018) is correct in identifying what he sees as an emerging ideology of Systemic Sustainability Education, where the prevailing educational metaphors are ECOSYSTEM and EMERGENT and within which teaching is conceptualised as DESIGNING and ENGAGING and learning is seen as EMERGENCE and a VIABILITY-MAINTAINING LIFE PROCEES, we may hope to see fewer educational metaphors being elicited that prioritise the TRANSMISSION and ACQUISITION of knowledge. Instead, we may find educational metaphors concerned with SUSTENANCE or FOOD FOR THE SOUL or NOURISHMENT or ENGLARGING CONSCIOUSNESS (Davis, 2018, p. 186) emerging in future studies.

Metaphors as orientations for action

How we think metaphorically matters as metaphors provide us with a means of acting towards the target concept. In other words, 'we act according to the way we conceive of things' (Lakoff & Johnson, 2003, 5). As noted by Craig (2020) when researching teachers' experiences of school reform, conceiving of humanly produced data as [G]od affords it a divine-like status before which teachers and school leaders are expected to bow reverently, leading, for instance, to the implementation of policies such as payment for performance. Similarly, each of the metaphors for understanding suggests its own way(s) of acting. If an educator conceives of 'understanding' as SEEING, for example, they are likely to provide their students with opportunities to explore the object of study from multiple perspectives and encourage them to critically reflect on the lenses through which they are looking.

WHY THE METAPHOR UNDERSTANDING IS UNDER-STANDING MATTERS

Above, we have argued that the metaphors we use in education matter as they act as powerful heuristics, carriers of epistemic and ideological freight, gatekeepers, springboards for change, and orientations for action.

As a powerful heuristic, the metaphor UNDERSTANDING IS UNDER-STANDING reveals an understanding of 'understanding' as primarily relational and positional. As with other metaphors for understanding, it carries ideological freight and an internal coherence with clear implications for (and perhaps a change in) practice. Understanding becomes TAKING A POSITION, where the role of the educator is to initiate their students into an encounter with the object of study, providing them with the opportunities and tools they need to view, observe and explore it from multiple (including domain specific) perspectives, before adopting their own position. This will not necessarily require any dramatic changes by teachers. It may only require giving the students structured time to reflect on such questions as, 'What do biologists find the concept of respiration is useful to explain?' 'Why do you think Henry the Eighth acted the way he did?' 'To what extent is the Jewish concept of *tikkun olam* (one group of people repairing the world) ethically sound?' (Walshe & Teece, 2025) and so on across the curriculum. This could be accompanied by explicitly introducing them to the metaphor UNDERSTANDING IS UNDER-STANDING as encouraging them to take a personal

position on what they are learning and helping them to focus on their own understanding of the topics. A powerful knowledge approach (Young, 2014) to the curriculum rather than a rucksack of knowledge approach (Dearden, 1968) would facilitate this. Moreover, approaches to teaching that prioritise the development of students' metacognitive capabilities would seem particularly appropriate here. Employing enquiry-based teaching and learning strategies and the deliberate and purposeful use of the (visual) metaphor UNDERSTANDING IS TAKING A POSITION, for instance, could increase the quantity and quality of students' metacognitive knowledge and monitoring skills, by helping them to distinguish between understanding and not understanding (Larkin et al., 2020).

If the way we think metaphorically matters and influences the way we act, then attending to the metaphorical nature of the term 'understanding' has profound implications for students' learning. Explicitly employing the metaphor UNDERSTANDING IS UNDERSTANDING as a metacognitive pedagogical tool may enable students to become more aware of their own standpoint (e.g. beliefs, values and assumptions) and the lenses through which they are viewing the object of study. After all, a person's situation is not merely a place from which to know, as the language of 'perspectives might imply... Situation is itself a place to know... It is an achieved epistemic stance' (Code, 2006 as cited in Lang, 2011, p. 88).

Moreover, if understanding as TAKING A POSITION is concerned with one's positionality in relation to the object of study, assessment practices in education could/should become less preoccupied with knowledge recall and more concerned with an appraisal of how a student's engagement with the object of study impacts on their understanding of both their own perspective(s) and those of others, and in particular, with the quality of evidence used by students to justify and explain their position. The use of teaching methods designed to develop students' skills of argumentation; their ability to critique ideas; evaluate evidence; and willingness to change their position in the light of new evidence, would be apposite.

CONCLUSION

In this article, we have argued that the term 'understanding' is fundamentally metaphorical.

By engaging in a process of re-etymologisation, we established the metaphorical character and potency of 'understanding' and explored some of the key implications for education. We have shown that awakening the sleeping metaphor embedded in 'understanding' reveals the fundamentally relational nature of what it means to understand—a view that sees understanding as a 'relational web' (Hager, 2007, p.7). Specifically, to understand is to TAKE A POSITION. As we have outlined above, this description of 'understanding' has significant implications for education, for example, in terms of how we as educators frame our educational intentions; the design of our curriculum; the pedagogical choices we make in our classroom practice; and in the assessment of our students' learning.

However, we must remain cognisant of the constraints as well as the affordances of metaphor. As with all metaphors, its explanatory power is partial (Lakoff & Johnson, 2003). No one metaphor is sufficient to provide a coherent and comprehensive account of reality (Guilherme & de Souza Freitas, 2018). Both popular metaphors for understanding (such as SEEING, CONSTRUCTING, GRASPING), and the metaphor UNDERSTANDING IS UNDERSTANDING highlight some aspects of what might be meant by 'understanding' and hide others (Deignan, 2010). They determine what is included in that description and what is left out (Ritchie, 2017). Indeed, Sfard (1998) warns of the danger of choosing just one metaphor. She explains how education is caught between two metaphors for learning, namely, the acquisition metaphor (where learning is seen as the act of gaining knowledge) and the participation metaphor (where learning is seen as an apprenticeship in a community of practice). Too great a devotion to one and a rejection of the other 'can lead to theoretical distortions and undesirable practical consequences'

(Sfard, 1998, p. 5). Whilst the metaphor UNDERSTANDING IS UNDER-STANDING illuminates the positional and relational nature of understanding, it cannot capture everything there is to say about 'understanding', and a question we are left with is, 'what aspects of understanding does this metaphor reveal and what aspects are left in the dark?' We explore this question in more detail in Walshe and Smith (2025). For the purposes of this article, it is sufficient to acknowledge that all metaphors are incomplete representations of something else (Fábíán, 2013; Lakoff & Johnson, 2003). If we neglect to recognise them as such, we fall into the trap of assuming they are the thing itself, and act accordingly (Rodgers, 2016). 'Under-standing' is not 'understanding'. As a metaphor, therefore, UNDERSTANDING IS UNDER-STANDING does not and cannot contain all aspects of what it might mean to understand. However, combined, metaphors such as SEEING, CONSTRUCTING, GRASPING, TAKING A POSITION furnish us with rich and fruitful descriptions of what it might mean to understand in the context of education. Whilst they may not be consistent, they are coherent (Lakoff & Johnson, 2003; Smith, 2018).

Moreover, metaphors can be misleading due in part to the various ways in which even one metaphor can be understood and in part to how educators may use multiple metaphors when talking about the same thing (Cameron, 2003). For instance, SEEING is not the same as TAKING A POSITION and yet they refer to the same target domain—understanding (Smith, 2018). Where metaphors have been misinterpreted, they have been shown to have a detrimental effect on learning (Littlemore, 2016). Research has also shown that the use of metaphor can be problematic for students who are accessing their studies in a language other than their first (Littlemore, 2016).

Moreover, whilst metaphors can uncover deeply held beliefs about educational principles and practices (Cushing, 2019; Fábíán, 2013), they can also limit, constrain and confuse (Rodgers, 2016) by keeping us within the confines of our former experiences (Guilherme & de Souza Freitas, 2018) and shaping what we see (Rodgers, 2016). We are ultimately responsible for the metaphors we privilege (Brouwer, 2012) as each 'has the potential to eclipse other ways of thinking and behaving' (Cook-Sather, 2003 as cited in Botha, 2009, p. 438). As an ontological and orientational metaphor, 'UNDERSTANDING IS UNDER-STANDING' not only arises from our physical and spatial experiences of being in and engaging with the world around us but can also govern the way we conceptualise that experience. We need, therefore, to be open to new possibilities and new metaphors, which may help us to see what we don't currently see (Brouwer, 2012).

Cook-Sather argues that education must be guided by 'life affirming, creative metaphors which foreground human relationships' and 'unsettle' (Cook-Sather, 2003, p. 162). It is her hope that 'educators will not stop with one metaphor or another but rather keep moving as new metaphors open up new spaces of imagination—spaces that may well re-animate old metaphors as well as lead us into unfamiliar spaces' (Cook-Sather, 2003, p. 965). We believe that UNDERSTANDING IS UNDER-STANDING is one such metaphor. Re-awakening the metaphorical prospects of 'understanding' has allowed us to re-think old material in a novel way (Goldstein et al., 2012), unlocking fresh possibilities for both thought and action; after all, 'educational change begins with talking differently' (Brent, 2018, p. 200). Conceiving of understanding as 'under-standing', with all that implies, offers a unique lens through which to critique current educational theory, policy and practice, to determine 'what needs to be maintained and what requires to be transformed' (Guilherme & de Souza Freitas, 2018, p. 953).

When considering the potential of any educational metaphor, Wineberg (2012) proposes that we ask the following questions:

- What values and obligations does the image presuppose?
- Does the image compel us to care for our students with more sensitivity and discernment?
- Does it direct us to where our concerns and duties ought to lie?
- Does it offer a standard that provides a corrective for inadequate or defective versions of practice? (Wineberg, 2012, p. 33).

As demonstrated above, to conceive of 'understanding' as inherently relational has profound implications for education; for the values and obligations we as educators privilege; for how we should care for our students; for where our concerns and duties ought to lie; and for the kinds of educational practices that we choose to promote. As an educational metaphor, 'UNDERSTANDING IS UNDER-STANDING' both 'thrills and delights' (Nelson, 2022, p. 8), revealing, once awakened from its slumber 'a diversity of novel perspectives and a world of new possibilities' (Guilherme & de Souza Freitas, 2018, p. 954).

In this article, we have demonstrated the metaphoricity of the term 'understanding'; explored its conceptual outworkings and entailments; and added to our ability to describe the relationships between the subject and the object of understanding, which we explore further in Smith and Walshe (2025). The resulting account, whilst not exhaustive, foregrounds previously concealed and obscured facets of what it might mean to understand. Moreover, by awakening 'understanding' from its metaphorical slumber, it is now free to go out into the world, and in particular, into our educational spheres, and 'work its wonders' (Davidson, 1978, as cited in Reimer, 1996, p. 18).

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